Of Laurel, Laurel, and Laurel Again

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by Lunaeryi

Summary

Two idiot heroes fake a relationship (badly) to stop a city-wide panic, accidentally win a footrace, get publicly bullied into pretending to be a couple over a pastry, and end up stargazing on a crumbling rooftop where feelings get dangerously close to becoming real. Aglaea would be proud. Probably.

Notes

Alright day one for Myphai week, I went with the mixed prompt of stargazing and hand holding👍 This is the only fic I hadn't beta read to check the pacing and whether I yapped to much or not until literally today 5 minutes ago, so bear with me as I realized I did a bit too much in certain areas (Which I didn't have time to redo), BUT the rest of the fics are better I promiseee.

See the end of the work for more notes

It was said that on the morning of the Bearing Dawn, when the first light struck the Dawn Device's crystal eye, even the Titans themselves stilled to watch.

Okhema, city of storm-worn stone and serrated spires, had endured another cycle against the creeping dark—and for this, the people rejoiced. Garlands of sun-dried laurel hung from the colonnades, their brittle leaves whispering as the dawn wind swept through marble avenues. Smoke from sacrificial braziers curled toward a sky washed in blue and gold, thick with the fragrance of crushed myrrh and wild rosemary. The streets throbbed with color and rivalry, bright sashes wound around waists and wrists, boys wrestling for thrown coins, and girls leaping to snatch laurel crowns from the air.

Hymns for Kephale, the Worldbearing Titan, rose from the open throat of the Temple of the Dawn, climbing skyward like threads of warm mist. Children's laughter laced between the solemn chants of the priests. Vendors cried out for honeyed figs and pomegranate wine. The city, battered but unbowed, turned its face to the sun.

And as tradition demanded, beneath the towering statue of Kephale, the elders gathered to recite the ancient texts—brittle vellum, weathered stone, and the lingering breath of memory itself. Okhema had always endured, and it had always known the price of endurance. Prophecies spoke of fire, of flood, of the sea's black hunger. Of traitors and Deliverers. Of crowns shattered and cities risen from ruin.

The finale reading—a solemn and sacred thing—was customarily reserved for the Prophecy of the Flame Chase Journey, for it was that tale which promised salvation against the Black Tide's encroaching dark.

But this year, as the people pressed close and the sun crowned the Dawn Device's eye, an unexpected addition was made.

And this, dear reader, is where our tale begins to properly unravel.

"Are you fucking kidding me?"

It wasn’t the kind of thing you were supposed to say in private during a prophecy reading, but Mydei had long since stopped pretending to care.

“Aglaea,” came a second voice, rough with exasperated laughter, “tell me you’re not serious.”

Inside the Vortex of Genesis, Mydei—Crowned Prince of Kremnos—glared across the room at the demigoddess in question. Beside him, Phainon, Deliverer of Okhema and long-suffering embodiment of patience-that-had-its-limits, leaned against a column like a man resigned to his own impending execution.

Aglaea, poised as ever, let out a sigh and pinched the bridge of her nose. “Titans preserve me,” she muttered, eyes closing briefly toward the ceiling. “I had hoped for one festival without theatrics.”

And thus—as always—the gods, the city, and the utterly unkillable pettiness of two would-be heroes conspired to disappoint her.

Phainon tipped his head back against the marble pillar, staring up at the ceiling as though the gods themselves might have the decency to intervene. When none descended, he let out a soft whistle.

“You know what? Never mind.” He pushed off the column with a lazy grace, gesturing at Aglaea with one hand. “Could you—humor me—repeat what you just said? Word for word.”

Aglaea’s expression didn’t shift. Not a flicker of irritation, not a ghost of indulgence. She spoke again in the same even tone, like reciting the most uninspired prayer.

“When the Crowned Shadow and the Wayward Flame entwine beneath the watch of dawn’s cold eye, the bonds of Okhema shall shatter, and night’s tide shall swallow the flame.”

There was a long, horrible pause.

Mydei blinked once. His voice came flat, deadpan, sharp enough to skin a man.

“You’re joking.”

“I suppose,” Phainon mused, turning the words over in his mouth like an overripe fig, “we had a good run.”

Aglaea sighed through her nose—not in exasperation, not in pity. It was the sigh of a woman far too dignified to engage with theatrics, and far too old to be surprised by them.

“It was not a request.”

Another pause. Phainon made a face like a man trying to decide whether to laugh or start climbing the nearest wall.

“And what, precisely, do you want us to do? Put on a little play? Hold hands, make moon-eyes at each other while the city cheers, and then hope the Council’s backroom bastards choke on their own slander?”

“That would be a start.”

Phainon let out a breath that was half-laugh, half-disbelieving groan.

“Gods, you’re serious.”

Aglaea folded her arms. “The Council has orchestrated a key public spectacle to incite panic and distrust. The prophecy implies—rather effectively—that the Crowned Prince of Kremnos and Okhema’s Deliverer will bring about the city’s collapse through betrayal or ill-omened unity. The phrasing is deliberate. It allows the Council to stir the public against both of you without openly condemning you, buying time to erode your influence and isolate the Kremnoans residing here.”

Mydei’s jaw clenched, though his tone stayed steady. “And your solution to this is…”

“A temporary courtship. A display of unity between Heirs. If the people see you willing, even reluctant, to bind yourselves together under Kephale’s light, we can twist the narrative. Reframe it. What the Council intended as a warning becomes a promise of peace. A gesture of defiance. At least until we can dismantle the prophecy’s momentum or—if it suits us—reshape it to our advantage.”

Phainon blew out a breath through his teeth, flashing a weary grin at Mydei.

“Well. Could be worse.”

“Name one way,” Mydei said flatly.

“We could have to kiss.”

Aglaea, without looking up, muttered, “That may yet be required.”

Both men immediately spoke over one another.

“No.”

“Absolutely not.”

Aglaea only closed her eyes for a moment, a brief prayer for patience to gods who no longer answered.

When she spoke again, her voice had softened, though not with pity.

“Mydei,” she said quietly. “The Kremnoans in this city look to you. They endure the stares, the slights, the old wounds that have not yet faded, because you wear their blood like a crown. If this prophecy takes root—if the people turn—they’ll be the first to suffer for it. The Council will ensure it.”

Mydei’s gaze stayed steady, though something flickered in the sharp line of his jaw.

“Your people can’t afford another civil riot,” Aglaea added. “Not when the Black Tide creeps ever closer to our gates.”

She turned then, to Phainon, and though her expression remained composed, there was a note of warning beneath it.

“And you, Deliverer, will find yourself alone if public sentiment shifts. The Council is waiting. They need the Assembly’s favor to dissolve the Heirs’ claim to the Flame Chase Journey. If the citizenry turns, the Assembly follows. And if they choose the Council over you… you already know what happens next.”

Phainon’s smile faltered, the humor draining from it, leaving something quieter in its place. He looked down, one hand absently fiddling with the signet ring on his thumb.

For a while, neither spoke.

Outside, a burst of festival drums rolled down the stone streets. A child’s high, reedy laughter cut through it, so sweet it felt like a knife.

Aglaea exhaled through her nose. “I ask for one day. A courtship of convenience. Public unity. A chance to reclaim the narrative before it hardens against us.”

She paused. Then, with the faintest, most cunning of smiles—the kind of smile only a demigod of romance could wield without detection—added, “And who knows. The gods do favor strange pairings.”

Neither of them noticed.

Mydei gave a sharp sigh, scrubbing a hand down his face. “Fine.”

Phainon grimaced. “Alright. Fine.”

“It’s for Okhema,” Mydei muttered.

“And the Kremnoans,” Phainon finished, squinting toward him. “Don’t get noble on me, Mydei.”

“Says the wayward flame.”

Aglaea did not smile. Not quite. But her eyes glinted.

“Good,” she said, and gestured to the archway leading out into the riotous streets below. “The city awaits.”

And as they left, the faintest stir of laurel leaves overhead whispered like a promise.

The city of Okhema had bloomed in gold and crimson.

Sun-dried wreath garlands looped from colonnade to colonnade, their leaves catching the light like old coins. Banners the color of hearth-flame and storm-lit dusk hung heavy over the streets, bearing the sigil of Kephale’s steady hand. Sacrificial braziers spat up sweet smoke—spiced wine, honeyed barley, sprigs of blood-bright pomegranate. The Dawn Device above the city blinked its glassy eye against the sun.

The air was alive with noise: children’s shrieks, the roll of festival drums, the clash of ceremonial shields. Old men debated verses from the Axionomicon, and lovers pressed each other into the shade of pillared courtyards. Rival crews from each district boasted their dawnfire runners would take the laurels this year, as they did every year.

Into this riot of scent and color, two figures stepped—and the air around them shifted.

The crowd tensed as they passed, the kind of wary hush that spoke of old grudges and fresh rumors. Whispers darted like minnows in their wake.

Phainon, as always, was irritatingly unbothered.

He hummed a snatch of some old soldier’s tune, casual as you please, and tilted his head toward Mydei, one brow raised. “Curious, were your festivals like this back home?” His voice was light, teasing even.

Mydei considered it for a moment. His eyes flicked over the offerings, the woven garlands, the half-drunk revelers. The tension in the air.

“Castrum Kremnos isn’t like this,” he said at last. “No braziers. No laurel crowns. No… whatever that is.” He gestured vaguely at a group of young men standing on each other’s shoulders while shouting profanities at a priest.

Phainon snorted. “I like them already.”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Our Bearing Dawn rites are different. Fewer festivities. More offerings at the ancestral pyres. Processions to the old wellspring. A sparring match at the end.” He hesitated, then added, softer, “My mother always said… if a man could bleed before the dawn, Nikador in honor of Kephale would carry his burdens for a year.”

Phainon glanced over at him, something flickering in his expression—before a sharp shout from the crowd made him glance away.

The tension around them was rising. Eyes lingered too long. Whispers thickened.

Mydei sighed. “Stay still,” he muttered.

Before Phainon could ask, Mydei reached out and grabbed his hand—none of the delicate politicking Aglaea might’ve preferred. He simply laced their fingers together, firm and final, as though daring anyone to say something.

Phainon blinked down at their joined hands. “Oh?” he said, the corner of his mouth quirking up. “Getting bold on me, prince.”

“Shut up,” Mydei muttered, not meeting his eyes.

Phainon grinned—the kind of grin that made men either follow him into battle or throw a punch at his face. “Didn’t think you cared what people thought.”

“I don’t. I care what they’ll do when panic sets in.”

Phainon hummed again, squeezing Mydei’s hand just once—to be difficult, and because he half-meant it.

“Well,” he said, letting the smile soften for a breath, “good to know you’re not just using me for my charm.”

“You don’t have charm.”

“Ah, lies, right to my face.”

Mydei exhaled something suspiciously close to a laugh, then promptly scowled to cover it.

They kept walking, and behind them, the whispers began to shift—wariness turning to curiosity, to tentative murmurs of perhaps, to the smallest, most dangerous kind of hope.

Neither of them noticed.

Phainon flexed his fingers around Mydei’s hand as they made their way through the festival streets, the murmuring crowd parting before them like wary fish. His grin lingered, but his mind was already moving three steps ahead.

So… what now?

He glanced sidelong at Mydei. The prince’s expression was the same impassive marble slab it always was, save for a slight twitch of his brow—a tic Phainon had learned meant he was just as lost.

Which meant Phainon, naturally, would have to save them.

He clapped his free hand against his palm. “Alright,” he said brightly. “We need to win the crowd, right? Show ‘em we’re all buddy-buddy, no secret plots to burn the city down together?”

Mydei gave him a look. “That was never the problem.”

“Details,” Phainon waved it off. “Point is—we mingle. We make nice. And what better way than the games?”

Mydei arched a brow. “The games.”

“Yeah. Y’know, good old-fashioned wholesome festival nonsense. Goat toss, hog fight, see who can drink the most fermented pomegranate before they puke themselves inside-out—”

Mydei’s brow furrowed. “You’ve done these before?”

“Please. Professer Anaxa once made me enter a torch race against three mercenaries and a man called Leontes the Flatulent. I’ve seen things.”

Mydei made a faint choking noise before suppressing it.

Phainon smiled wider. “C’mon, you telling me you wouldn’t pay good money to see me wrestle a hog in a ceremonial tunic?”

“I’d pay to see you lose,” Mydei said dryly.

“Oh? You think you’d do better?”

Mydei smirked, just a fraction.

They were *this* close to shaking hands on it when the air around them shifted.

A sudden, bone-deep chill threaded through the sun-warmed streets, like a silk cord drawn taut around their throats. Every hair on the back of Phainon’s neck stood up. Somewhere overhead, a single gold thread shimmered against the sky—thin as a hair, bright as vengeance.

Phainon froze mid-step. “Oh,” he said, very softly. “Right.”

Mydei sighed: “She’s listening.”

They stood there a moment, the festive din blurring around them.

Then, with all the stiff dignity of a man carefully pretending he hadn’t just suggested suplexing livestock for public approval, Mydei cleared his throat. “Let’s do the relay.”

Phainon nodded solemnly. “Excellent choice.”

“Appropriate. Dignified.”

“Aglaea-approved.”

They didn’t dare look up again, but somewhere, they could feel the distant flicker of satisfaction, like a breeze ruffling through gold thread.

Phainon exhaled through his nose, already starting to smirk again. “You know we’re gonna make this a competition, right?”

“I’d be offended if you didn’t.”

“Hope you can keep up, Crowned Shadow.”

Mydei’s eyes gleamed. “Hope you can, Deliverer.”

And just like that, the petty rivalry was back on—one dumb, over-competitive foot race away from diplomatic catastrophe.

If Aglaea hadn’t already been exasperated, she would be by the end.

The Relay of Kephale’s Grace *sounded* noble. It sounded like the kind of event where polished athletes in gleaming bronze took to the track with garlands in their hair and hymns on their tongues.

It was not.

What it actually was—and what both Phainon and Mydei realized only when they arrived at the starting post and caught sight of the tangle of knotted ropes and cackling, drunken Okheman locals—was a two-legged relay.

A two-legged relay.

Each team of two had their adjacent ankles bound together with sun-bleached cloth and were expected to limp-run their way around the winding city square, passing a ceremonial baton at the halfway point. The winner wasn’t whoever finished first.

It was whoever made it without eating dirt.

Phainon stared at the tied ankles. Then at the crooked circuit. Then at the sky as if asking some higher power to smite him swiftly.

“Fuck me,” he muttered, heartfelt and sincere.

“Later,” Mydei replied without missing a beat. “Run first.”

Phainon turned his head very, very slowly.

Mydei didn’t blink.

For one long, silent moment, only the sounds of festival drums, distant shouting, and someone loudly vomiting behind a brazier filled the air.

Then, a corner of Phainon’s mouth twitched upward. “Kremnoan humor,” he said dryly. “Sharp as ever.”

“Only when you deserve it.”

They stood there for another heartbeat before a grizzled old officiant with three teeth and a ceremonial laurel crown that looked like it had seen better centuries shouted, “RIGHT THEN, TEAMS TO THE LINE!”

Phainon sighed, pulling his boot off to start tying their ankles together. “Well,” he said, his grin returning despite himself, “let’s make the gods regret inviting us.”

“Wouldn’t be the first time.”

The drums quickened. The crowd pressed closer.

The starting horn blared—a long, warbling note that sounded suspiciously like someone choking on a conch shell.

Phainon and Mydei launched forward.

Immediately, disaster.

“Left foot, you idiot—!”

“No, your left—!”

They both tried to lead at the same time. Mydei surged ahead, naturally faster, cutting a tight corner around the first brazier. Phainon stumbled, overcompensating with his longer stride, and nearly yanked them both sideways.

“For the love of—stop pulling like a *feral dog*, Deliverer!” Mydei snapped, elbowing him sharply.

“Oh, I’m the problem?” Phainon grabbed Mydei’s forearm mid-stride, hauling him back into line. “You cut that corner like a damn thief!”

“It’s efficient.”

“It’s cheating.”

“Semantics.”

They careened around a laurel-draped pillar, bumping into a pair of older women holding platters of honeyed figs, narrowly avoiding a sticky catastrophe.

A random spectator, clutching a mug of spiced wine, shouted, “Gods, they’re gonna kill each other!”

The crowd laughed, but not unkindly. There was a certain chaotic charm in watching two of the city’s most famously impossible men try and fail to cooperate for public sport.

Somewhere high on the temple steps, Krateros pinched the bridge of his nose.

Meanwhile, Mydei grit his teeth, yanked Phainon’s wrist with surprising strength, and muttered, “Stop showboating and run.”

“I *am* running,” Phainon hissed. “I’m running while saving *your* reckless behind from toppling over like an oak in a storm!”

“Metaphors won’t save you when I throw you into the brazier.”

“Oh good, it’s *death threats* now.”

Mydei grunted. “Always was.”

They reached the halfway mark—a crooked stone post with a ceremonial baton balanced precariously atop it. The next phase: grab it without tripping.

Phainon took a deep breath. “Truce for three seconds.”

“Five.”

“Three and a half.”

“Four.”

“Done.”

They both lunged for the baton at the same time.

And because they were who they were, elbowed each other in the ribs doing it.

They both seized the baton at once, fingers tangling. Neither yielded.

“All is fair in war,” Phainon grinned.

“Including breaking your nose,” Mydei shot back, and they shoved off the post in sync, sprint-limping down the uneven stones.

That’s when the rival team came for them.

Two broad-shouldered men in dyed blue sashes—the mark of Council sympathizers, Phainon recognized them immediately. One feigned a

stumble and veered toward them.

Mydei didn’t even look.

He casually drove a flat palm into the man’s chest. The guy grunted, air whooshing from his lungs, and stumbled back into a pile of stacked amphorae.

Phainon laughed, slinging an arm around Mydei’s shoulders for balance as they nearly toppled. “I’m beginning to like you,” he said, using the momentum to hurl both of them forward.

They didn’t so much hit their stride as crash into it.

By accident, their steps started to sync up. Mydei’s pace compensating for Phainon’s longer reach. They slipped between weaving racers and hurdled over a toppled crate of oranges.

The other teams, though—gods.

A gangly fishmonger with bare feet and wild hair darted past them, cackling. Two burly stonemasons cracked their knuckles and grinned ominously, clearly out for blood. A married baker and his wife argued loudly about flour debts while still managing to maintain an impressive lead.

And then there was the old woman.

Bent, toothless, moving like a storm’s herald, she shot past them with terrifying speed.

“Is she mortal?” Phainon whispered shouted.

“Don’t ask questions you don’t want answered,” Mydei snapped, tugging Phainon back toward the main path.

A cheer rose nearby.

Phainon instinctively turned, spotting a small cluster of Kremnoan expats—tough-looking men in worn tunics, raising cups of wine and shouting for *“Crowned Prince Mydeimos! Dawn’s Edge! For Kremnos!”*

And the bastard waved back.

Phainon immediately yanked him by the wrist, nearly tripping them both. “Focus, Your Highness.”

“They’re my *people*.”

“You can sign autographs later!”

They rounded the final corner, tied ankles burning, the finish line in sight. The crowd was wild—a riot of color and sun-hardened faces, cheering with reckless glee.

Phainon grinned, wind whipping his hair. “You ready?”

Mydei’s mouth quirked. “Always.”

They leaned into it, running as one.

The final stretch was madness as wagers were shouted from balconies.

“Twenty credits on the Deliverer’s pretty face eating dust!”

“Fifty says the Prince strangles him before the finish!”

Phainon grinned like a jackal. “Hear that? I’m the *pretty one*.”

“Pathetic works too,” Mydei muttered, refusing to look at him.

In retaliation, Phainon yanked Mydei off-balance with a sharp tug on their tied ankles, nearly sending both of them skidding into the dust.

“You son of a bitch,” Mydei gritted out, catching himself with a hand on Phainon’s shoulder, teeth bared.

“Fair’s fair,” Phainon sang.

And then—something shifted.

Without a word, like they’d done it a hundred times before in the training sands, on bloodied streets, in a dozen embassies where neither should’ve survived—they locked in.

Mydei set the pace. Phainon matched it.

They ducked under a swaying banner, hurdled over a broken amphora. The place erupted in cheers as the pair of them hit full stride, legs moving as one, sun gleaming off bronze and sweat-slick skin.

They crossed the finish line with a breath to spare.

The crowd howled. Somewhere, a lyre struck up a triumphant chord.

Panting, both half-collapsed against each other, too winded to gloat.

From the shade of a laurel-draped stoop, an old Okheman crone squinted at them.

“They make a good pair, eh?”

Her neighbor snorted, spitting a plum pit into the dirt. “Bet they’re married by dusk.”

Both Phainon and Mydei made the same strangled, horrified noise.

Then remembered why they were doing this.

They straightened up, plastered on matching stiff, princely smiles—and turned to face the roaring crowd.

The gods, it seemed, were not without humor.

“I think,” he puffed, eyes squinting up at the brilliant, pitiless sky, “I’ve got one… maybe two more of those in me before I start composing an ode to

Thanatos.”

Mydei was perfectly upright, save for the faint pink flush at the tips of his ears. He didn’t even bother looking at Phainon as he spoke.

“You’d have to learn how to count first.”

Phainon chuckled, winded but grinning. “You wound me, your highness.”

A pair of children darted past, carrying sun-bright ribbons and shrieking with laughter. Somewhere nearby, an old musician plucked at a lyre, his song floating lazily through the festival haze. The air smelled of sweat and sweetened wine.

Phainon took a slow breath, watching a group of Okhemans hoist one of the race’s elders onto their shoulders in mock triumph. He tilted his head.

“You know,” he said, almost thoughtful, “this isn’t so bad.”

Mydei grunted. “Don’t get sentimental. It’s a weakness.”

“Is it?” Phainon smiled, gaze catching on a cluster of Kremnoans in their crimson-edged cloaks, cheering for Mydei still, not him. And somehow, that made him smile wider.

Before either could speak again, a hush spilled like ink across the place. Not sudden—not a crash of silence—but a ripple. The way soldiers stop mid-drink. The way old dogs lift their heads.

Mydei’s spine straightened before the voice came.

“Deliverer.”

The word landed heavy. Like an old iron brand.

Phainon stiffened. His stomach tightened as he turned, already knowing who it was before his eyes confirmed it.

Krateros.

The old man cut through the square like a blade, flanked by two grim Kremnoan guards. The man was built from war-torn years, a living relic of a time when Kremnos bled at the walls and spat in the teeth of gods.

Phainon rose to his feet. Beside him, Mydei's face remained unreadable, though a flicker of something passed through his gaze.

"Teacher," Mydei greeted, his voice clipped, respectful.

"Sir," Phainon echoed, dipping his chin.

Krateros' gaze lingered on them both. The weight of it made the bright, laughing world feel suddenly narrow and sharp-edged.

"I've heard… things," Krateros said, his tone a low roll of distant thunder. "Rumors. Whispers."

Phainon managed a smile, polished, easy. "Festival talk, I'd wager. Too much wine, too many bold tongues."

He clapped a hand to Mydei's shoulder, fingers resting there as if he belonged—a gesture too practiced to be an accident. "Though if you must know, your prince and I have found ourselves… momentarily entangled."

Mydei didn't so much as blink.

Krateros did not look amused.

A long beat of silence stretched thin.

Then, the old soldier spoke again, but not to Phainon.

"I would speak to your consort. Alone."

Phainon blinked. "I'm sorry?"

Krateros' expression never changed. "A matter of honor."

He turned, already moving, and Phainon shot a glance at Mydei—who, for all his grace and steel, gave the smallest, most unhelpful shrug known to mankind.

“Oh, don’t let me stop you,” Mydei said mildly, voice like oiled blades.

Phainon sighed through his nose, dragging a hand down his face. “Of course. Wouldn’t dream of it.”

He followed after Krateros, the bustle of the festival feeling oddly distant, the scent of burning laurel thick in his throat. Just before the crowd swallowed him, he glanced back.

Mydei was watching him, one brow lifted in the faintest, most insufferable of smirks.

“Good luck, pretty one,” Mydei murmured.

“I swear to every god, I’m putting poison in your bathwater.”

Krateros led Phainon through a narrow passage between two old stone structures. The sounds of the festival dulled here, replaced by the faint drip of water and the muffled hush of ancient stone.

The general came to a stop beneath the battered arch of what might once have been a home. The walls around them were pitted from old battles—arrows long gone, but their scars remained.

He turned, fixing Phainon with a stare honed on decades of warfare.

“I’ll be plain,” Krateros said. “I do not like you.”

Phainon huffed a soft, humorless laugh. “I’d be disappointed if you did.”

Krateros didn’t smile. He stepped closer, the air between them thick.

“You are reckless. Proud. And you lead with your heart—a dangerous thing in a man who carries so many lives in his wake.”

A pause.

“I’ve buried men who wore brighter smiles than yours.”

Phainon swallowed, jaw tightening, but to his credit, he didn’t look away.

“And yet,” Krateros went on, voice lower now, “Mydeimos… has not dismissed you. And if my prince sees fit to grant you his regard—however begrudgingly—then I would be remiss not to ensure you understand the gravity of what stands between you.”

Another step closer. Close enough that Phainon could see the fine white scars webbing the man’s throat.

“I raised him from a boy in a city that would eat him whole if it meant another day of peace. I’ve bled for him. Killed for him. And I will see his life protected until Thanatos herself drags me to the underworld.”

The words hung there.

“And you,” Krateros said, his voice sharp now, “will tell me plainly, Deliverer—what are you to him?”

Phainon stared at him. A hundred easy deflections leapt to his tongue. A hundred witty dodges, practiced expressions, and glib remarks.

None of them fit.

Not here.

So, surprisingly genuine, he answered the only way he could.

“I’d bleed for him before I’d harm him.”

The words came without fanfare.

Just truth.

A long silence followed, heavy as the stone around them.

Krateros regarded him, the hard line of his mouth unreadable. Then, after what felt like an eternity, the old captain gave a low, approving grunt.

“Good.”

He turned, his voice losing none of its edge. “See that you remember it.”

Without another word, he strode away, leaving Phainon alone.

Phainon let out a breath he hadn’t realized he was holding, scrubbing a hand down his face before casting a glance back toward the sunlit city beyond.

“Gods,” he muttered to himself. “I am so screwed.”

And with that, he followed the sound of revelry back to the festival.

When Phainon emerged from the shadowed passage, blinking against the glare of late afternoon sun, he expected to see Mydei standing aloof as usual—arms crossed, posture stiff, gaze like a whetted blade.

Instead, he saw… this.

A loose circle of grimy-faced street kids had clustered around the Crown Prince of Kremnos like a pack of bold sparrows. Mydei crouched low among them, one knee in the dust, a length of leather cord in his hands. He moved with the quiet economy of someone who’d done this before—deft fingers showing them how to tie a quick-release knot Kremnoan scouts used when caught in thorn-thick forests.

Phainon slowed, watching as one of the kids, a wild-haired boy no older than seven, leaned in.

“Is it true you fought a Black Tide beast with your bare hands?” the boy asked, eyes huge.

The knot stilled in Mydei’s hands for a heartbeat. Then he looked up, expression unreadable.

“It was already half-dead when I found it,” he replied evenly.

The children exploded into shrieking laughter like it was the funniest thing in the world.

A small, rare tug at the corner of Mydei’s mouth betrayed the faintest of smiles.

Phainon found himself smiling too, surprised at the warmth curling under his ribs where he’d expected cold, hard stone.

Eventually, a passing street crier called out the next round of festival games, and the children scattered like leaves on a breeze—shouts of “Did you see the prince’s face? He *smiled*!” trailing behind them.

Phainon approached as Mydei rose, brushing dust from his hands.

“Didn’t take you for a children’s entertainer,” Phainon drawled, leaning against a sun-warmed column.

“They were curious,” Mydei murmured, watching the last of the kids vanish down an alley. “Better that than afraid.”

There was a beat. Then, without looking at him:

“What did he say?”

Phainon hesitated, the weight of Krateros’ words still heavy in his bones. He could feel the old man’s gaze on the back of his skull even now.

But he shrugged, smoothing the hesitation into a grin.

“Oh, you know. The usual. Don’t disgrace the bloodline. Keep your hands to yourself. Don’t screw this up. Standard father-figure threats.”

Mydei turned his gaze on him, sharp and measuring.

Phainon held it a second too long. Then blew out a sigh and, true to form, dodged the question.

“Anyway,” he said lightly, clapping Mydei on the shoulder as if they hadn’t both just had conversations heavy enough to drown a god. “What do you wanna do next? Win another race? Rig the goat toss? Steal a pastry from that old woman who nearly broke my knee earlier?”

Mydei’s lips twitched.

“I think,” the prince said, “I’ll let you pick. Since you’re so intent on dragging me into your nonsense.”

Phainon grinned. “Oh, you’ll regret that.”

And together, they drifted back toward the heart of the festival—two shadows trailing in the long-golden light.

The honeyed pastries glistened in the late afternoon light, stacked in a neat pyramid atop a worn linen cloth. Their scent—fried dough, wildflower honey, a hint of orange peel—curled through the air like a siren’s lure.

Phainon reached for the last one at the same time Mydei did.

Their hands brushed. Both paused.

“You take it,” Phainon said smoothly, pulling his hand back with a gracious smile. “Wouldn’t want to deprive our noble prince.”

“You were here first,” Mydei replied. “Go ahead.”

“It’s fine.”

“I insist.”

They locked eyes over the pastry, neither willing to back down, both pretending it was pure politeness and not sheer stubborn pride.

The old auntie running the stall, wrapped in a sun-bleached scarf, clucked her tongue fondly.

“Ah, young couples,” she sighed, propping a fist on her hip. “Always so considerate.”

Both men froze.

“We’re not—” Mydei started, a pulse jumping in his jaw.

“He’s mine,” Phainon cut in smoothly, wrapping an arm around Mydei’s shoulders before he could bolt, smiling at the vendor.

Mydei’s face made a very particular expression—the kind that, had they not been on a delicate mission to manipulate public sentiment, would’ve been immediately followed by a homicide.

Instead, he forced a tight smile and, in a move born purely of self-preservation, reached up and covered Phainon’s hand with his own. He squeezed just hard enough to bruise.

Phainon winced. “Affection,” he muttered under his breath. “Show of affection.”

Before either of them could retreat, the vendor laughed, leaning forward eagerly.

“Then you’ll know the custom,” she said. “Two sweethearts courting in public must feed one another a bite of something sweet for Kephale’s favor.”

Mydei went still.

Phainon blinked. “I’m sorry, what?”

The woman waved a hand. “It’s tradition. Brings good fortune. The whole of Okhema would tell you.”

And indeed, a handful of passing festival-goers had slowed, catching the exchange. One of them blushed. Another elbowed her friend.

“Go on!” someone called.

“Let’s see it!”

More voices joined in, a rising tide of cheerful, relentless nosiness.

Mydei’s eye twitched. He glanced at Phainon.

“This is absurd.”

Phainon made a show of weighing his options—then let out a dramatic sigh, plucked the pastry from the cloth, and broke it in half. Honey dribbled over his fingers.

“Fine,” he said, almost sheepish, though the gleam in his eye said otherwise. “Just this once.”

He held the bite-sized piece out to Mydei.

There was a long, terrible beat of silence. Mydei stared at the offering like it was a live serpent. Then, very slowly, he leaned in and, without breaking eye contact, took the pastry from Phainon’s fingers with a sharp snap of his teeth.

Someone nearby whooped.

Phainon coughed, covering his smiling face with the back of his hand.

“Kephale bless you both,” the vendor said, beaming, and tossed a sprig of laurel over their heads.

When the small crowd dispersed, leaving them standing awkwardly alone, Phainon licked honey from his thumb.

“So,” he said, voice light, “did you wanna hold hands again or just skip straight to planning the wedding?”

Mydei took a slow, lethal step forward.

“I will end you.”

Phainon laughed. “Love you too, sweetheart.”

They walked on—one radiating murderous intent, the other laughing like he’d just gotten away with murder. Which, in a way, he had.

By dusk, the streets of Okhema were a glorious mess.

Somewhere along the way, Mydei and Phainon had apparently decided to see how many public spectacles they could accidentally win without dying.

There’d been the tug-of-war against a team of Kremnoan warriors twice their combined size. (They won.)

A lyre-off between Phainon and a smug artisan’s son. (Phainon cheated. Brazenly. Still lost.)

An impromptu wrestling match Mydei won by sheer ruthless technique, pinning his opponent in a hold so efficient it earned grudging applause from even the Okhemans.

And a string of minor games and challenges—rope pulls, coin tosses, insult duels (Mydei was disturbingly good at those)—all undertaken in the name of unity, morale, and if Aglaea’s threads were still listening, convincing public affection.

Now, long after sunset, the festival fires had turned the streets into a blur of gold and shadow. Musicians played half-drunk hymns to Kephale. Laurel petals clung to sweaty skin.

Phainon tipped his head back against a warm stone wall and exhaled a ragged sigh. The wreath crown someone had shoved onto his head hours ago was askew, and his clothing was wrinkled, honey-stained, and missing a fastening at the shoulder.

“The procession’ll be soon,” he murmured. “One more thing, and then I’m retiring to a damned bathhouse and possibly dying there.”

Mydei—no more composed, though he'd never admit it—leaned nearby with his arms loosely crossed, watching the glow of firelight play against the walls. His hair was mussed, dust and flower petals clinging stubbornly to it.

"Is that so?" he drawled. "Anything in particular you're thinking?"

Phainon hummed, a low sound in his throat, as if weighing the wisdom of saying it aloud. He let his gaze drift to the sky—an endless stretch of dark blue smothered by the eternal gold glow of Okhema's lantern-fires. No stars. Never any stars.

"I'd love to see the stars," he said lightly, almost laughing at himself for it, then made a dismissive gesture. "Ridiculous, I know."

Mydei's brow twitched. "Elaborate."

Phainon shot him a look, one brow arched. "Didn't think you were the sentimental type."

"I'm not," Mydei deadpanned. "But you opened your mouth, so now you're finishing the thought."

That earned a small, wry smile from Phainon. He leaned his head back again, looking toward where the sky ought to be.

"Okhema's light never ends of course. But there's this… story. I jsed to hear it when I was a kid, probably made up by a drunk sailor or an old madwoman. It was said that during Kephale's festival, if you found the right place at the right hour, and looked just the right way—you could see the stars through the city's veil. Not from Kremnos, not from out in Aedes Elysiae. Here. In Okhema."

He gave a small, self-deprecating laugh.

"Tried looking once or twice over the years when I got here. Don't know why. Guess it felt stupid. Never found it, obviously."

Mydei didn't speak.

Phainon glanced sideways, half-expecting a sardonic remark or the usual dry retort. Instead, the prince's face was unreadable, gaze fixed somewhere past him, distant and sharp.

Then Mydei pushed off the wall with a quiet breath.

"Follow me."

Phainon blinked. "Wait, what?"

But Mydei was already moving, weaving through the thinning crowds with the same calm, imperious grace he wore on battlefields. No explanations. No second offers.

After a beat of startled hesitation, Phainon chuckled to himself and followed.

"Stars," he muttered under his breath. "Alright, your highness. Show me a miracle."

And he did.

They slipped away from the festival like thieves.

Okhema's streets were still alive with scattered bursts of music, but the press of bodies thinned the farther they went. Petals clung to the paving stones. Smoke hung in the air like a half-remembered hymn.

Phainon kept pace easily beside Mydei, stealing sidelong glances.

"So," Phainon drawled, sidestepping a drunk man passed out in a doorway, "do you always drag your political decoys off into dark alleyways, or am I just special?"

Mydei didn't slow. "I reserve it for the ones who humiliate me during public games."

Phainon snorted. "Please. You were smiling when I yanked you face-first into that pastry cart."

“Was I?”

“Like a man seeing the gods.”

A flicker of something that might’ve been a smirk tugged at the corner of Mydei’s mouth. He cut through a narrow passage between two leaning stone tenements, then ducked beneath a sagging line of prayer flags.

Phainon followed, still half-beaming. “You sure you’re not lost? Because it really seems like we’re heading toward either a murder spot or a lovers’ hideout, and frankly, I’m not sure which one of those makes more sense for you.”

Mydei gave a quiet hum, faintly amused. “You talk when you’re nervous.”

“I talk when it’s quiet,” Phainon corrected, stepping over a crooked paving stone. “The silence makes me itch.”

Another passage. The city’s heartbeat growing softer behind them.

Phainon tilted his head, watching as Mydei reached for a rusted iron gate, barely clinging to its hinges. “You sure about this, your highness?”

“No,” Mydei said, pushing it open with a dry creak. “But you wanted stars.”

And without waiting for a response, he slipped through.

Phainon hesitated only a heartbeat, then ducked in after him.

“Not how I imagined being led to my doom,” he muttered, ducking under a curtain of wild ivy. “But points for atmosphere.”

Somewhere ahead, Mydei’s voice, lower and softer than before: “Stop complaining. You’ll like this.”

And for reasons he couldn’t quite explain, Phainon believed him.

The last of the stairwell gave way to sky.

Phainon blinked as he stepped out, the faint scent of flower and old stone thick in the air. The rooftop garden stretched before him—if it could still be called that. Twisting vines clung to crumbling walls, drooping under their own weight. Wild and half-dead flowers clawed their way through cracks in the stone, blooming defiantly in the forgotten corners. A toppled statue of Kephale lay on its side, half-swallowed by creeping moss, the old god's stone face softened by time and ivy.

The city spread out beneath them in a scattered tapestry of light and shadow. Fire braziers burned along the high streets, flickering in the dusk, and ribbons of smoke curled lazily up toward the darkening sky.

And there—between two leaning spires, one of marble and the other black basalt—a slender seam of pure, undiluted night stretched overhead. A narrow corridor of unclaimed sky. No temple light reached it. No bronze lanterns dared intrude.

And in that thread of darkness, faint, scattered pinpricks of starlight.

Phainon stopped dead.

For once, no clever line, no practiced words. His breath caught somewhere behind his ribs.

"You…" He swallowed, staring. "You actually found one."

Mydei was already there, leaning against the broken remains of a pillar as though he'd been waiting for hours. His posture was casual, but he didn't meet Phainon's eyes.

"I said I knew a place," he murmured, voice too carefully even.

But his ears were red.

Phainon let out a laugh—soft, breathless, and more genuine than anything he'd offered all day. The sound of it broke whatever tight, uncertain thing had hung between them since the morning.

“This is…” He gave a low whistle, running a hand through his hair. “Better than any pastry.”

A pause. The sound of distant festival drums, softened by height and distance. The fragrance of old laurel and sun-withered blooms.

Neither of them moved to fill the quiet.

For once, it felt like there was no need to.

They ended up sitting side by side, backs against the same broken pillar, the faint hum of the city carrying up like a far-off tide. The quiet wasn’t awkward—just… still.

Phainon absently hummed some half-remembered tune under his breath, fingertips tapping an idle rhythm against his thigh.

Then—

“There,” Phainon whispered, sharp with sudden excitement as he pointed upward. “Look.”

Mydei turned his head, following the line of Phainon’s hand. A single, stubborn star hung in the narrow seam of sky. Faint, but undeniably there.

“You’re acting like it’s your first time seeing one,” Mydei remarked.

“In Okhema?” Phainon grinned sidelong at him. “It is.”

Mydei huffed something like a laugh and tipped his head back against the stone.

Time unspooled strangely after that.

No talk of councils. No muttered worries about prophecies or titles or shadows on the horizon. The festival’s muffled din faded into background haze, leaving them alone in their high, hidden corner.

They spoke of inconsequential things.

Phainon asked about the odd knot Mydei had shown the street kids earlier—when he'd learned it, why Kremnoan scouts used it. Mydei explained, demonstrating it with a stray length of vine. In turn, Mydei asked what song Phainon had been humming. Some old half-forgotten drinking ballad from his hometown, Phainon admitted, though his mother used to sing it when she was angry with his father.

They traded stories of bad food eaten on long campaigns. Argued over whether the rivers north of Okhema or the southern cliffs had better sunrises. Phainon swore by the cliffs; Mydei, after a moment's stubborn silence, quietly conceded they might be equal.

At some point—neither sure when—they found themselves leaning shoulder to shoulder, legs stretched out in front of them, just two figures silhouetted against the patch of night sky.

The stars didn't grow any brighter. The city didn't quiet.

But here, for a little while, it didn't matter.

"…and I swear to every god that listens," Phainon was saying, gesturing animatedly with one hand while the other absently picked at a loose thread on his cuff, "if you ever find yourself in the market square of Aedes Elysiae during their midsummer fair, do not—and I mean this—do not try the pickled squid. I don't care how drunk you are, how much someone dares you, or what you're promised in return. It's a death sentence."

Mydei made a faint, amused sound—something between a huff and a scoff. "I'll add it to my list of vital Kremnoan wisdom."

"You should. That's survival advice, not idle conversation."

They were both slouched comfortably now, the neglected garden sighing around them in the night air. The faint glow of Okhema below painted the stones gold and amber, a thousand torchlights flickering like restless insects. Somewhere down in the streets, a musician's pipe carried on the breeze, thin and reedy.

Mydei flicked a pebble at Phainon’s knee. “I doubt you’d survive half the street markets in Kremnos.”

“Maybe not,” Phainon said, stretching his legs out. “But I’d die full and pleased with myself.”

The conversation meandered like that, one story tumbling into the next. Mydei spoke, uncharacteristically easy, of the southern coast near Kremnos—narrow beaches where the stones shimmered red at sunset, and the fishermen swore salt spirits made their nets heavy. Phainon, in turn, told of the long nights during his youth, of the time he and a childhood best

friend tried to convince an entire tavern they were long-lost royal twins, and how they’d nearly pulled it off until a goat ate half the forged proclamation.

It wasn’t meaningful conversation, not by anyone’s measure. But it was honest.

Then, a low, resonant bell tolled from the heart of the city.

The sound rippled out over the rooftops, a long, mournful note that marked the hour before the Bearing Procession. In the streets below, the torches would be gathering. Priests and council members threading toward Kephale’s statue.

Mydei stirred, already bracing a hand on the stone to push himself up.

Phainon reached out and caught his wrist.

“Wait,” Phainon said, voice quieter now, eyes fixed on the seam of dark sky above them. “Maybe we… stay a little longer.”

Mydei gave him a look—brow faintly arched, the prince’s habitual reserve sliding back into place.

“Aglaea’s likely just going to twist the wording,” Phainon added, more lightly, shrugging one shoulder. “Dress it up, soften the sharp edges. Wouldn’t hurt if we let them stew for a bit. You know how the Council hates being kept waiting.”

For a moment, Mydei didn’t reply.

Then—a small, rare thing—he smiled. A real one. Subtle, and only half there, but unmistakable.

“Alright,” Mydei murmured. “A little longer.”

Phainon exhaled, leaning back against the stone once more. He let his head tip back, catching the line of that single star still hanging stubbornly above them.

He bumped his shoulder lightly against Mydei’s. “Thanks, Mydei.”

The prince just huffed again, but didn’t move away.

And for a while longer, the garden held them—the city humming below, the star above, and the world waiting.

End Notes

Alright day one wrapped, I haven’t finished day 7 yet but I think I’m close😭? But yeah, ty for reading <3333

Oh yeah, come follow me on Twitter so we can tap abt these idiots : https://x.com/thelunaeryi?s=21

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